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The News Journal, Wilmington, Del. Thursday, Feb. 5, 1998, Section D

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INSIDE: D4-D5

Beauty spot gives a lift to strollers

S. Lap Jung, proprietor of Jung's Antiques and Art, which faces the 1300 block of Pennsylvania Avenue in Wilmington, tends a garden that has been a frequent winner in Delaware Center for Horticulture's annual City Gardens Contest. He recently wrote in with a wish for the Chinese Lunar New Year, observed Jan. 28: "May the Year of the Tiger, 4696, bring you Peace, Health, Wealth, and a Bountiful Garden!"

He also shared his philosophy of gardening: "My garden is a labor of love which I enjoy sharing with everyone. The challenge of trying new varieties each year so that there is something in bloom all season long is very satisfying. Every few weeks, I try to have a different display of flowers, blending color, form and height. Growing plants from seeds allows me to share the excess with fellow flower lovers." Spoken like a true gardener!

Mr. Jung, your efforts give pleasure daily to hundreds of commuters, and it's even better for those of us who come by on foot!

Backyard Gardener

Nancy Wingate

Winter dormancy

Every summer, I buy a few plants that I can't resist, even though I know they're not winter-hardy here in zone 7. They're happy in pots in the summer sun, and even during the autumn chill, but every winter, I struggle to find a way to winter them over. Usually, I just toss them away to people who have created greenhouse-like environments for their houseplants.

Well, this year, for the first time, I'm letting some of my tender plants hibernate, and it's working beautifully. I have two Confederate jasmine vines from Roanoke, Va., a Duke's jasmine vine from my mother's Gulf Coast garden, and even a couple of stray spider plants. Late in November, I set them all up in the basement, near the front windows. It's downright eerie: For nine weeks now, they've stayed green, haven't lost a single leaf, and appear to be in a state of suspended animation. I check them every week and water maybe once a month, when the soil in the top of the pot feels really dry.

Jo Mercer, horticultural extension agent with the New Castle County Cooperative Extension Agency, confirms that they are in a state of suspended animation: They've entered "semidormancy." Many plants naturally enter a yearly "resting period," during which they make no active growth. By creating unfavorable environmental conditions, I'm enforcing an extended resting period. (The metaphor of sending a tired toddler off for nap time is irresistible.)

In this semidormant state, they're not actively growing, and are therefore happy with cooler temperatures, low light and infrequent watering. In the early spring, when temperatures begin to rise, they'll start growing again and might get leggy, so they may need to be moved to a transitional spot until it's warm enough to put them outside again.

Bulb grants for schools

Educators interested in using flower bulbs to enrich learning and beautify school grounds are invited to apply for the Mailorder Gardening Association's "Kids Growing with Dutch Bulbs" awards this spring.

The program will award 40,000 flower bulbs to 200 schools nationally.

To receive a grant application, send your request to: National Gardening Association, Department. MP,180 Flynn Ave., Burlington, VT 05401; call (800) 538-7476; or send e-mail to eddept@garden.org. The application deadline is May 1.

▶Nancy Wingate is a free-lance writer and gardener from Wilmington. Write to Backyard Gardener, The News Journal, Box 15505, Wilmington, DE 19850; fax 324-2415; or send e-mail to features@wilmgt.gannett.com.

The Hidden Faces of China

Maryland artist Hai-Ou is reclaiming her heritage with art that focuses on the country's minority peoples.

By CHERYL LU-LIEN TAN
The Baltimore Sun

Growing up in Beijing, Hai-Ou wondered why she looked so different.

Her cheekbones were higher, stronger, more distinct than those of most other Chinese.

"When I was young, I always felt I was ugly," she said, cupping her face. "I didn't know why I looked so different."

Hai-Ou, 40, found out her cheekbones came from the Tibetan grandmother she never met, from Tibetan landowning kin her father was forced to renounce during China's Cultural Revolution in the 1960s.

Hai-Ou remembers her father spinning tales about his boyhood. The more she heard, the more she felt a "shen-mi gan," or a curiosity, about her family's mysterious past. But it would be decades before Hai-Ou, who now lives in Crofton, Md., explored her heritage.

She did that through art, and her explorations adorn the Maryland Federation of Art Gallery on the Circle in Annapolis. "Minorities of China," a collection of 32 pieces, is on display through Sunday.

The works — charcoal sketches, soft watercolors and commanding oils — feature girls, women and men from China's minority groups in bright garb, holding up labor-etched hands or posing with animals. The most eye-catching pieces are brilliant canvases of Tibetan monks in front of a temple, marching in procession, blowing on bright silver horns.

Hai-Ou is afraid her audience will see political statements she hasn't brushed into her Tibetan work. She wants nothing to do with Richard Gere, the Tibetan freedom movement or the wave of recent films on the topic.

Her paintings, she insists repeatedly, are about herself, her family, her closing the circle for her father.

Her parents, an accountant mother and intelligence-officer father, named her Hai-Ou — sea gull in Mandarin — so she would soar high above the ocean waves (Hai-Lan in Mandarin and her father's name). Her father grew up near Tibet in Gansu and had wanted to be an artist, but his family sent him to prestigious schools in Beijing to become a government official instead.

His artistic yearnings took root in Hai-Ou, who began sketching colorful Chinese opera characters when she was 4. Her childish drawings were "lost" during the Cultural Revolution from 1966 to 1976, during which opera and all else considered bourgeois had to be renounced.

Her father was forced to sever ties with his family in Gansu, who were landowners — enemies of the Communist movement. He symbolically dropped his family's last name — Hou — and never spoke to his family again.

"After the Cultural Revolution, he began thinking a lot about his family and he felt very sad and wanted me to add his [family] name to mine," Hai-Ou said. "But I still prefer Hai-Ou. It sounds better."

Her father's loss intrigued Hai-Ou. Surrounded by half-finished paintings in the tiny basement studio of her home, Hai-Ou began in rat-a-tat Mandarin to recount her father's fascinating stories about how Tibetans lived near the mountains and hunted bears.

"He said when Tibetan women gave birth, they would get up, tell their husbands, 'Wait here for a moment; I'm going to the bathroom. I'll be back soon,' and then they'd come back carrying a child," she said, laughing incredulously.

Hai-Ou was among one of the first generations of students to attend college in the post-Mao era — Chinese universities

See CHINA — D2

Hai-Ou, 40, who is today an accomplished painter, grew up during China's Cultural Revolution, when much art was officially frowned upon.

The Baltimore Sun/PERRY THORSVIK

IF YOU GO

What: "Minorities of China" art exhibit
Where: Maryland Federation of Art Gallery, 18 State Circle, Annapolis
Hours: 11 a.m. to 5 p.m. daily. Show closes Sunday.
Admission: Free
Information: (410) 268-4566

Turning trash to treasure

Architectural relics transplanted, reborn

By DYLAN LANDIS
Universal Press Syndicate

A man dressed in a good suit walked out of an elegant New York restaurant one night, spotted a Dumpster at the curb and climbed inside. A hotel nearby was being renovated, and the rubble seemed full of promise. His catch: an elegant wrought-iron lighting fixture, adorned with someone's spaghetti dinner.

This is architectural salvage — the rescue (as opposed to theft) of building fixtures and ornamentation for reuse in other sites. In this manner, an old elevator indicator lamp, with "up" and "down" bulbs on a sculpted base, now lights a modern bathroom, and a 1850s elevator grille serves as a headboard.

"Not so long ago, architectural ornament from demolished buildings was considered trash," write Evan and Leslie Blum, the brother-and-sister authors of "Irreplaceable Artifacts: Decorating the Home With Architectural Ornament" (Clarkson Potter, $35).

Tons of ornament from Chicago's Cable and Republic Building were dumped into Lake Michigan in pre-preservation days. Sculptures from New York's Pennsylvania Station were carted

See SALVAGE — D2

Limestone columns that once supported arches on a cornice now support a glass coffee-table top; terra-cotta flower is purely decorative.

David Foster photo

Black-oriented sites abound on the Web

By BILL O'BRIAN
The Washington Post

As the Internet grows, it is increasingly fostering networks of like-minded people, whether for practical ends like commerce or for broader goals such as building political communities. An array of Web sites attempts to help African-Americans on both levels — from employment opportunities to culture and literature.

One place to start is EverythingBlack (www.everythingblack.com), a sort of megamall home page. It displays 12 broad categories — from arts and humanities to business, entertainment and travel — that offer links to hundreds of Web sites, including African-American community news outlets all over the country.

There are numerous specialized sites, too. Mosaicbooks.com,The Black Literary Showcase (www.mosaicbooks.com), an affiliate of online bookstore Amazon.com, features summaries and recommendations on current black and Hispanic literature. Black Facts Online (www.blackfacts.com) is a fledgling database/search engine that aspires to be "Your Internet Resource of Black History Information."

Black Urban Professionals Online (www.buppic.com) provides parenting tips, a résumé data bank, guidance on personal finance, and professional and social calendars. The Black Collegian Online (www.black-collegian.com) offers career advice and a state-by-state job database. And that's just a smattering.

For children, Shelton Jewette, owner of Computers 101, a Washington, D.C., computer training center, recommends the Afro-Americ Kids Zone (www.afroam.org/children/children.html), which includes fables, games, puzzles and brain teasers.

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